

Fall of Saigon

The Vietnam conflict had begun as a guerrilla war, but victory came to a military force plentifully equipped with armored vehicles and heavy artillery. Hopes of a negotiated end to the war vanished when the North Vietnamese Army entered Saigon as conquerors.

◀◀ BEFORE

After the withdrawal of US troops from Vietnam in 1973, fighting continued between the South Vietnamese government and the joint forces of North Vietnam and the Viet Cong.

ISOLATED AND OVERPOWERED

Political developments at home led to the US abandoning its promise to provide military support to South Vietnam. **Weakened and demoralized** by the drying up of American aid, South Vietnamese forces collapsed under heavy attack in **Spring 1975**. The **evacuation of Saigon** began at the start of April 1975.

By resigning on April 21, 1975, President Nguyen Van Thieu signaled the opening of the Vietnam conflict's brief concluding phase. His departure was a public admission that South Vietnam had lost the war, as the last hope of US intervention had disappeared. Vice President Tran Van Huong, who had succeeded Thieu, called for a ceasefire and negotiations to end the war through adherence to the Paris Peace Accords. This proposal was rejected by the communist leadership.

Intent on offensives

Back in early April, the North Vietnamese politburo had given its senior commander, General Van Tien Dung, orders to pursue the military offensive until Saigon was taken. They had no reason to change their attitude once their forces were on the verge of victory.

General Dung launched the final drive against Saigon on April 26. The city was surrounded, with all major roads cut by Dung's forces. South Vietnamese troops had not given up—there was an especially fierce encounter between the rival armored forces at Long Thanh east of Saigon—but the superiority of the communist side in numbers and weaponry was overwhelming. On April 27, the first NVA rockets were fired into Saigon's center.